Burners Principles

The rules in [[Burners Adventure Game]] and the satellite books are built on a short list of design commitments. They are the spine behind every subsystem — combat, magic, gear, social play, and porting OSE modules. When a corner case arises, ask which principle the moment serves, then route it through the subsystem that already implements it.

Two engines

The World Engine is how the world behaves on its own terms. People, monsters, and places have a nature that does not bend to a wish.

The Hero Engine is how you act: you say what you do and roll against the Risk.

Player skill decides whether the world bends; your Approach decides only how much effect you have. A good idea, well told, makes things happen. Your sheet makes them happen harder. It never makes the impossible possible.

Dice only when there is a Risk. The dice come out when the Referee names a Risk. What could possibly go wrong? Unpaid Risk is **Heat**, which the Referee may spend as scene consequences or convert to HP. Time, noise, position, or a Spicy twist may ride alongside. A safe and certain action just happens. There is no Persuade roll for whether the world bends; that is Step 1. Heart amplifies a success the fiction already grants; it never manufactures an impossible one.

Granular defense, not binary save

Burners has no save-or-die. Endurance is **Defend** — a graded contest, not a gate you pass or fail.

- **Out of combat**, a hazard is **`2d6` + the fitting Approach** against the Referee's Risk. You may soften the bite, bear it whole, or dodge it clean — but the outcome is a matter of degree, not a single on/off switch.
- **In combat**, blows land. You **burn Fuel dice** and cut the blow by their faces. Leftover, armor soaks; anything still left comes off HP. Defend, Cover, Block, Counterattack — full rules in [[Burners Adventure Game]] — are ways to answer a blow, not a roll that erases the hit. Monsters take damage on their **Monster Stack** (2 × HD cards) — face-down first, then face-up (Referee speed).
- **Hostile magic** uses the same Fuel economy as steel. The caster's **cast total** (sum of faces spent to cast) opposes your **defense total** (sum of faces you commit). Partial defense means partial effect: **overrun** = cast − defense, applied as harm to HP *or* as the spell's hold — never both. There is no "save for half" — you defended as well as your dice allowed.

A binary save asks *did you avoid it?* Burners asks *how much did you stop, and what is left?*

Procedure: *Approach Roll* (hazards) and *Defending* under Combat in [[Burners Adventure Game]]; *Defending against a spell* in [[Burners Sorcerie]]; *The Defend Router* in [[Burners OSE Conversions]].

Attrition, not spike damage

Lethality lives in **attrition and ambush**, not in big single numbers. Your Fuel only shrinks over a fight; when it runs dry, blows arrive whole. Ambush is loadout and tempo: sheathed steel means a thin Fuel open, and surprise on round 1 puts that side dead last — you still act. Arrows, holy water, fire, and meals are counted — you have what the sheet says.

Past 0 HP, blows open **Wounds**; each is a Shock Check (combat-effective). After the fight, unhelped Wounds kill; helped, a Craft survival check decides. The stack and the survival roll kill you — not a single failed save, not the passage of time alone.

Steel and sorcery share the same pool. The danger is the turn you are winded with workings still flying.

Taking foes out (Referee speed): monsters get **2 × HD** playing cards (**face-down** closed / **face-up** open). Soft kit paints more face-down; naked/sushi stay all face-up. **Hits = ⌈damage ÷ 5⌉** always; closed → **−1**, always (armor is one card of soak). The **right tool** lets the player burn one extra Fuel into the blow. **Cracked!** = last face-down gone (signal; the −1 ends). **Dead** when the stack is empty. No free Defend; no negative band. [[Burners Referee Guide#Monsters at speed (preferred Referee mode)]].

HP is plot armor; past 0 it gets real

HP is plot armor — luck, wind, near-misses. Blows come off HP and you shrug them. Nothing is torn yet.

Past **0**, the shit gets real. Overflow opens a **Wound**: a negative tally that is your actual flesh, a location, an effect, a Shock Check for combat footing.

Reach full HP and every wound closes — tally, penalties, soft-target marks. Maimings offered at the brink are the exception.

Death lands after the fight — **unhelped Wound**, **failed Craft survival**, or a **coup de grace** on a helpless body — not from classic level loss, and not from Shock alone.

Heat is collateral

Heat is the crew's shared bank of **collateral** — unpaid Risk that will come back to bite. Approach-roll shortfalls are always Heat. The Referee spends it as the mess the job is making, and may convert Heat into HP when the bite is on a body.

- Heat is **never a damage buffer in a fight**; blows land on HP, not Heat. Conversion is for out-of-combat Heat the Referee spends that way.
- Heat is **not** monster Initiative — foes use a **group 1d6** (see [[Burners Adventure Game#Combat]]). Optional press is separate. **Don't double-count dread:** the creature's Monster Stack and weapon quotes are its own; Heat prices only the situation — the dark, the alarm, the flanking.
- Module foreshadowing is mechanical: boxed danger is a **Heat raise**; rooms that let the party prepare are Heat reductions waiting to be claimed.
- When the party splits, each live scene runs its own Heat.

Earned in play

Traits come with levels; named gear and spell learning are **never bought with XP**. Signatures emerge at the table — one per level in that Approach, or two per character level if **Eldar** ([[Burners Experience#Eldar]], [[Burners Ancestry#Eldar]]).

Magic arms and armor are looted or earned, never bought at creation. Magic items grant **0 XP**; the item is the reward. Enchanted = legendary = eldritch: a *+1* is a magic sword. It **accepts** only a matching Trait (no roll) — a free die each round and powers once found: [[Burners Adventure Game#Enchanted Arms and Armor]]. How you stock and convert them: [[Burners Referee Magic Items]].

Invocations are not Sorcerie

An **Invocation** is a bargain, not a spell. No hand, no Sorcerie slots, no school Trait. **Patron Alignment** is not Sorcerie level — a torch-hand may be Lunara 3 and never cast; a Sorcerer may know every school and stand a stranger to every god.

Not wishes. Players will reach for Invocations whenever they are stuck. The **Risk roll** gates whether a patron hears you; the **Offer and Ask** are where the Referee balances what you get against what you owe. Neither is a menu for rewriting the scene.

Sweet and Spicy vs Spark

Out of combat, **Sweet** (6) and **Spicy** (1) ride alongside the sum and never change it. Double Sweet is the perfect roll; double Spicy is a fumble.

Combat has no Sweet or Spicy. There you read the dice you burn; a 6 is a **Spark** — an opportunity you normally must Fuel with another die to use. Unfueled, it fades. Nothing fumbles in combat. Enchanted "on hit" powers key off Sparks, not Sweet or Spicy, and a 1 burned with an item you have the Trait for adds the item's slots — see [[Burners Adventure Game#Combat]], [[Burners Sorcerie]], [[Burners Referee Magic Items]].

Sword owns the press

In combat, only **Sword** answers. The diplomat, locksmith, and archmage are bodies in the melee until they escape the press. Spend other mastery before blades draw — ambush, parley, ward, position.

Pools, not fixed numbers

Preferred (Referee speed): each enemy group rolls **1d6** for Initiative every round. Attacks are **free quotes**. Durability is the public **Monster Stack** (2 × HD cards, face-down / face-up) — see [[Burners Referee Guide#Monsters at speed (preferred Referee mode)]]. Burners still roll fat Fuel pools (Initiative = count of 3s and 4s) and burn faces to attack and Defend. Round 1 surprise puts a surprised side dead last — no lost turns.

Optional (full-dice foes): run a named foe like a character — Fuel pool, burn to attack and Defend — when you want the slow fight. **Order stays a group/solo 1d6**, not a 3/4 Fuel count. Most nights, don't.

Spells work the same way for casters: cast at least SL Fuel dice; the **cast total** is the attack value.

When porting material that prints a flat damage number (a trap, a breath quoted in hp), convert by the die or treat it as a telegraphed area effect — never paste a legacy save and a legacy damage line and call it done.

Traps have no pool: flat Damage from the die average. Defend with Fuel if you have dice up; take it whole if you don't. A trap is **detect or eat** — scouting buys the telegraph.

Armor soaks; monsters use Monster Stacks

Armor (AC) is what a Burner wears — a flat soak subtracted from leftover after Defend, before HP. It never enters the exchange as a die.

Monsters do not use PC AC. Deal **2 × HD** playing cards (Referee speed): **face-down** (closed / armored), **face-up** (open / meat). Soft kit **adds face-downs into the mix**; naked / sushi / tough hide with no kit stay **all face-up**. True shell/plate → mostly or all face-down. See [[Burners Referee Guide#Monsters at speed (preferred Referee mode)]] and [[Burners OSE Conversions]].

Pop face-down first. Hits always ⌈damage ÷ 5⌉; closed → −1, always — armor is one card of soak. The **right tool** (*slice the sushi*, *poleax the shell*) lets the player burn **one extra Fuel** into the blow — a deeper cut, not a waiver. No locked gate — the claim is theirs.

Twenty militia hacking a plated crab each bounce or chip face-down cards while it kills them. That is correct; it is why the village hired Burners.

No plusses on sums. A +n from another game never becomes a bonus added to a roll total. It becomes **enchanted** arms or armor — see [[Burners Referee Magic Items]].

Harm and effect are separate lanes

When a hostile working overruns your defense:

- **Damage:** Defend a **physical** manifestation — conjured blade, stone shards, dodgeable cone — then leftover, a Burner's AC soaks, rest to HP 1:1. **Non-physical** workings ignore AC. Monsters take it face-down then face-up (Referee speed).
- **Control** (charm, sleep, fear, command…) never chips HP. Fully defended: nothing. Defense fell short: the working takes hold — full or partial per the spell and the overrun (Referee's call on edge cases). Recover when the working ends or is broken.

Never both harm and hold from the same working on the same target. OSE *save for half* does not port.

No instant death

Poison, paralysis, petrification, death rays, and wounds from the Fallen route into subsystems Burners already has:

- a **Defend** to avoid the touch;
- a **lingering Cost** (level in HP per round for level rounds, no further defense);
- a **counting doom** (repeated Defends, each miss a step toward stone);
- **Wounds** and **Shock Checks** (combat-effective), then **help + Craft survival** after the fight — see [[Burners Adventure Game#Wounds]];

- a **telegraphed area effect** you Ward (if magic), cover, or eat.

Any of the Fallen (undead) that **wounds** you leaves that Wound — not level loss. Midnight: `1d6` + HD, then survival; Incendiary purge; spawn if unclean. Full procedure: [[Burners Referee Guide#Undead]].

Death comes from **failed survival** (after a fight, after Midnight, or after a purge), **unhelped Wounds**, or a **coup de grace** on a helpless body — not from a single failed save out of combat, and not from classic level loss. The Referee may offer a maiming at the brink instead.

Telegraph the unwinnable

A **monster** area effect — dragon breath, a collapsing ceiling — is often the blow you cannot slip as an ordinary Fuel Defend against a cast total. The Referee telegraphs it ("its chest glows") so cover, eating the quoted damage, or (if the breath is **hostile magic**) a Sorcerer's **Ward** is a **choice**, not a gotcha. Mundane cones and collapsing stone are not Warded.

A **spell** cone or burst uses **Defend** and overrun like any other hostile working.

No gotchas

Burners puts information on the table on purpose. Fuel is face-up. Heat is announced. Threats are telegraphed. The crew chooses with eyes open — they may still choose badly, but they were not ambushed by a rule they could not see.

Warn before the irreversible. If a move will spring a sharp interaction the player may not have clocked, say so, then let them decide. Example: a shot with a friend in the line and no 6 to burn — it will hit the friend. *"Are you sure? Aldric's in the line, and you've got no 6."* Procedure: [[Burners Referee Guide#Line of attack]].

Hidden monsters, sealed doors, and lies in the fiction are fair. Hidden *rules* are not.

Route, don't reinvent

Every die, save, check, and bonus from another game is a **pointer** to a Burners subsystem — not a new mechanic to copy.

Legacy idea	Burners route
Ability check	Approach roll (`2d6` + Approach)
Save vs. hazard	**Defend** (`2d6` + Approach) vs Risk
Save vs. spell	Fuel **Defend** vs **cast total**; roll initiative if no fight yet
Save vs. breath (monster)	**Area effect** — telegraph, ward, cover, or eat it
Save vs. poison	**Defend** (Craft) to avoid; **lingering Cost** once it lands
To-hit / THAC0	Deleted — the pool carries the attack
Magic weapon to hit	Face-down cards; players claim the **right tool** for the extra die

Legacy idea	Burners route
+n weapon or armor	Enchanted: one free die a round when used, minor powers
XP for magic items	0 XP — the item is the reward
XP for monster parts	0 XP — purse or kit; see [[Burners Experience#Part out]]
XP for treasure on return	Credited at the deed, found or not; see [[Burners Experience#The deed pays]]

The full OSE routing tables live in [[Burners OSE Conversions]]. Read a stat block once, write the margin note — 2 × HD cards (face mix), Heat dish, right-tool-if-any — and run it.

What this means at the table

- **Read the moment.** Is the world bending to a clever plan, or is there a price? Pick the engine.
- **Spend dice.** Defense is a resource decision, not a permission check.
- **Name the harm.** Face-down cards and weaknesses are fiction first; players claim the right tool for the extra die.
- **No gotchas.** Face-up Fuel, announced Heat, telegraphed threats — warn before a sharp rule bites (a shot through a friend with no 6), then honor the choice.
- **Telegraph the big hits.** Dragon breath and collapsing ceilings are choices, not surprises sprung cold.
- **Let the dread work.** Lingering Costs and wound severity do the horror; the Referee does not re-roll every round.
- **Face the Heat dial.** Collateral waiting to bite: foreshadowing in module text is a raise; preparation is a reduction.
- **Don’t double-count dread.** Creature stats and scene Heat (collateral) are separate levers.

When two rules seem to disagree, the principle wins — then find the subsystem that already implements it.